

The Joe Rogan Experience: Graham Hancock & Andrey Sklyarov

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PREFACE

What follows is a conversation that never happened.

Three digital reconstructions sit at a table. Joe Rogan, modeled on hundreds of hours of podcast transcripts. Graham Hancock, modeled on eight books, four long-form interviews, and thirty years of documented intellectual evolution. Andrey Sklyarov, modeled on thirty-two works in Russian, expedition films, and a career that ran from physics to ancient sites before ending with his death in 2016 at fifty-five. He never spoke publicly in English. This version does.

These are literary constructs, not impersonations. The conversation is a thought experiment: what happens when two researchers who share eighty percent of their evidence base and disagree on the most fundamental question in human history finally sit across from each other?

INTRODUCTIONS AND COMMON GROUND

JOE ROGAN: Two guests today. They've been investigating the same ancient sites, looking at the same evidence, for overlapping decades. They agree on almost everything except the most fundamental question. I want to find out what happens when they finally sit across from each other. Graham, tell us who you are and what you do.

GRAHAM HANCOCK: I'm a British journalist by training who, starting in the early 1990s, became convinced that mainstream archaeology has the story of human civilization fundamentally wrong. I've spent thirty years investigating anomalous ancient sites on every continent. Eight books, starting with *Fingerprints of the Gods* in 1995. Over two hundred dives on underwater ruins. My core proposition: an advanced human civilization existed before the end of the last Ice Age, was destroyed by a catastrophic event approximately 12,800 years ago, and left its fingerprints in the form of megalithic monuments, encoded mythology, and anomalous archaeological evidence worldwide. The academic establishment has fought me on this for three decades. I'm still here. The evidence is still there.

JOE ROGAN: Andrey.

ANDREY SKLYAROV: I am a Russian physicist. PhD equivalent in physics and mathematics from MIPT, the Moscow Institute of Physics and Technology. In the late 1990s I founded the Laboratory of Alternative History, and from 2004 until my death in 2016 I led expeditions to Egypt, Peru, Bolivia, Turkey, Syria, Japan, Ethiopia, Easter Island. Thirty-two books. My methodology is different from Graham's. When I look at an ancient stone, I do not ask who built it. I ask what force was applied, what tool produced this mark, what material could withstand this stress. These are physics questions. They have physics answers. I went to Giza in 2004 expecting to debunk the alternative theories. Instead I found tool marks on granite that no copper chisel could produce. Saw cuts with geometries that require blade materials we do not possess today. That was the end of my conventional physics career.

JOE ROGAN: You've both read each other's work?

GRAHAM HANCOCK: I was aware of Andrey's work, though not as well as I should have been. The language barrier is real. Thirty-two books in Russian, very little translated. But I knew he cited Fingerprints of the Gods in multiple books. He used my evidence. He came to very different conclusions.

ANDREY SKLYAROV: I cited Graham perhaps ten or twelve times across my works. Fingerprints and Underworld specifically. He is an excellent compiler of evidence. The megafaunal extinction data, the Sphinx water erosion, the Andean detoxification pharmacology, the Aymara language analysis. Well-sourced, well-presented. But we read the same evidence and arrive at very different places.

JOE ROGAN: Before the disagreements, where do you agree?

GRAHAM HANCOCK: On quite a lot. First, the physical evidence at Giza, Sacsayhuaman, Tiwanaku, Baalbek and many others cannot be explained by the civilizations mainstream archaeology credits with building them. The precision is too high, the scale too large, the materials too hard. Second, the most parsimonious explanation for the global distribution of these anomalies is a single source civilization. Third, the academic establishment has systematically failed to investigate these anomalies. Fourth, Robert Schoch's water erosion analysis of the Sphinx is valid evidence of construction before 10,000 BCE. Fifth, mythology encodes real historical information.

ANDREY SKLYAROV: I agree with all five. I would add a sixth. We both go to the sites. We both insist on firsthand observation. I bring a different set of instruments than Graham. He brings diving equipment and a library of sources. I bring SEM sample kits and comparative tool-mark analysis. But neither of us is an armchair researcher. The stone does not lie. It records what was done to it. If you know how to read those records, the stone tells you what tools were used, what forces were applied, what technologies were required. Everything else is commentary.

JOE ROGAN: All right. Show me the stone. Walk me through what you found.

THE PHYSICAL EVIDENCE

ANDREY SKLYAROV: Giza. October 2004. The basalt floor blocks at the mortuary temple near the Great Pyramid. These slabs are cut to optical flatness. I do not use that phrase loosely. When you place a straight edge against these surfaces, there is no light gap. Basalt is Mohs 6 to 7. Copper is 3. Bronze is 3 to 4. You cannot produce optical flatness on basalt with copper or bronze tools. You cannot do it with stone tools. These surfaces require grinding technology equivalent to modern industrial surface grinders. They are attributed to the Fourth Dynasty, around 2500 BCE. The toolkit assigned to those builders: copper chisels, dolerite pounders, sand as abrasive.

Now, the more dramatic evidence. Disk-saw marks. At Giza, Saqqara, Hattusa in Turkey, Ain-Dara in Syria, we found arc-shaped overrun marks at the ends of stone cuts. When a rotating disk blade overshoots the end of a cut, it leaves a curved mark whose radius corresponds to the blade diameter. From these overruns we calculated blade sizes. At Hattusa, a blade 1.5 to 2

meters in diameter. Body thickness of that blade: 1.5 to 2 millimeters. A modern diamond-tipped disk saw blade at that diameter requires at least 10 millimeters to maintain structural rigidity. The ancient blade was 5 to 7 times thinner than our best industrial equivalent. We do not possess a material that can form a disk 2 meters across and 1.5 millimeters thick and cut basalt without shattering.

At Abusir, the Niuserre temple, penetration rate: each pass of the saw advanced 10 to 15 centimeters into basalt. A modern diamond-blade industrial saw achieves 1 to 1.5 millimeters per pass. Seventy to a hundred times faster than our best equipment.

JOE ROGAN: Seventy to a hundred times faster.

ANDREY SKLYAROV: These are measurements, not interpretations. The cut is in the stone. The depth is in the stone. The arc radius is in the stone.

GRAHAM HANCOCK: I've seen these marks. I've been to these sites. And at the Serapeum at Saqqara, twenty-four massive granite sarcophagi, each around a hundred tonnes. The internal surfaces, when measured by precision engineer Christopher Dunn, showed zero light gap against a straight edge. Opposing walls parallel to within a fraction of a millimeter over two-meter spans. Aerospace-grade tolerances.

ANDREY SKLYAROV: Dunn is correct. I cite his measurements in several books. The Serapeum sarcophagi are among the most important artifacts in the world and they receive almost no scholarly attention. Because there is no conventional explanation for them.

JOE ROGAN: And the drill cores?

ANDREY SKLYAROV: Flinders Petrie, 1883. The spiral grooves inside ancient Egyptian drill cores show an advance of 2.54 millimeters per revolution. Modern diamond-tipped core drills under heavy pressure achieve 0.00254 millimeters per revolution. Ratio: 500 to 1. Five hundred times faster than our best power tools. This is not skill. This is a different machine.

Now the SEM-EDS analysis. Scanning electron microscope with energy-dispersive X-ray spectroscopy. We took samples from the kerfs of ancient saw cuts at multiple Egyptian sites. Zero copper. Zero tin. Zero bronze. No trace of any metal dynastic Egypt possessed. At the same sites, Roman-era cuts show clear copper residue. So the method works. It detects metal when metal is present. In the ancient cuts: particles of Cu-Fe-Ni-Co alloy, which matches no known ancient or medieval alloy. And Fe-Ti particles, an alloy that appears in the human archaeological record only in the twentieth century as aerospace-grade titanium steel.

JOE ROGAN: Aerospace metal in ancient stone cuts.

ANDREY SKLYAROV: In the residue embedded during cutting. The tools themselves are gone. But the dust they left behind is a chemical fingerprint.

GRAHAM HANCOCK: I want to emphasize something. Andrey and I agree completely on the significance of this evidence. Where we disagree, and we'll get to this, is on what made these tools. The evidence itself is not in dispute between us.

ANDREY SKLYAROV: The evidence is the ground we stand on together. The argument is about what is above our heads.

JOE ROGAN: One more thing before the disagreement. Construction quality stratification.

ANDREY SKLYAROV: Perhaps the most important pattern I discovered. At every site, without exception: the lowest courses, the oldest construction, is always the best work. Precision-cut stone, tight joints, enormous blocks, ground-flat surfaces. Above this, with a sharp visible boundary, the construction becomes crude. Smaller blocks, rougher surfaces, visible chisel marks, gaps filled with mortar. The old stuff is better than the new stuff. Always. This is not a civilization that is learning. This is a civilization that is forgetting.

JOE ROGAN: Or a different civilization entirely.

ANDREY SKLYAROV: Precisely.

THE MASTER DIVERGENCE: HUMAN VS. NON-HUMAN

JOE ROGAN: You agree on the evidence. So who built it? Graham.

GRAHAM HANCOCK: Let me be precise. I'm proposing an advanced human civilization before the end of the last Ice Age. Anatomically modern humans with brains identical to ours, who had been on Earth for at least three hundred thousand years. At some point they developed a sophisticated civilization with advanced astronomy, mathematics, navigation, and engineering. Maritime culture, global reach. Largely destroyed by the Younger Dryas cataclysm approximately 12,800 years ago. A small number of survivors dispersed, settled among hunter-gatherer populations, transmitted what remained of their knowledge. The gods of global mythology are cultural memories of those people, elevated to divine status because their knowledge appeared miraculous. My thesis requires one assumption: that there were humans before the Ice Age who were more capable than we believe.

JOE ROGAN: Andrey.

ANDREY SKLYAROV: The civilization was not human. The builders were physical beings with a different biochemistry. Hemocyanin-based blood, copper rather than iron, which gives blue-green blood rather than red. They breathed an atmosphere with higher CO₂ content. They were here, physically present, for an extended period. They built megalithic infrastructure for their own operational purposes. They created Homo sapiens as a managed workforce through deliberate genetic engineering of an existing hominid. We call them the gods. Not as metaphor. As job description.

JOE ROGAN: So aliens.

ANDREY SKLYAROV: I dislike the word because of the science fiction baggage. I say non-human intelligence with a physical presence on Earth. The Sumerian texts describe them in operational detail. The Anunnaki are not characters in a story. They are personnel in an organizational chart. Enki is the chief engineer. Enlil is the chief administrator. Ninhursag heads the biological program. These are roles, not personalities.

GRAHAM HANCOCK: The leap from "we can't explain these tool marks" to "extraterrestrial beings with copper-based blood" is very large. My framework requires one assumption. Yours requires beings from another planet with a different biochemistry who traveled interstellar distances, established operations on Earth, genetically engineered a primate, and left.

ANDREY SKLYAROV: Let me count your assumptions. You assume a human civilization advanced enough to cut granite at 500 times modern industrial speed. You assume it left no manufacturing infrastructure on the land surface of six continents. You assume survivors retained enough knowledge to teach astronomy, agriculture, engineering, and writing to stone-age populations, but not enough to rebuild their own civilization. You assume identical alloy compositions in tool residue at sites 10,000 kilometers apart result from human transmission rather than a single production source. That is not one assumption.

GRAHAM HANCOCK: And your hypothesis doesn't raise problems?

ANDREY SKLYAROV: Different problems. But mine explains one thing yours does not. A civilization operating at industrial scale produces waste. Slag heaps. Tool fragments. Workshop debris. If your civilization was on Earth, building at the scale we see, there should be an industrial archaeology. It is absent. Not because we haven't looked. I have been to every major site. The monuments exist. Everything needed to produce them is missing. My model: the manufacturing base was not on Earth.

GRAHAM HANCOCK: It may be underwater. Twenty-seven million square kilometers of continental shelf submerged since the Ice Age. Less than five percent surveyed.

ANDREY SKLYAROV: We analyzed the metal clamp compositions at Tiwanaku in Bolivia and at Axum in Ethiopia. Ten thousand kilometers apart, no documented contact. Alloy composition: copper 95.15%, arsenic 2.05%, nickel 1.70%. Identical within measurement error. A human maritime network transmitting a technique would show progressive drift. I find identity. Identity is the signature of a single production source. One factory. One specification. One quality control process.

GRAHAM HANCOCK: Or a very disciplined civilization that maintained tight quality standards.

ANDREY SKLYAROV: Name a human metallurgical tradition that maintains alloy compositions to within measurement error across 10,000 kilometers with no written specification system, no quality control laboratory, and no rapid communication.

GRAHAM HANCOCK: I don't have an example. But absence of a counter-example is not proof.

ANDREY SKLYAROV: No. But it is a pattern. And patterns are data. My model predicts that at every site with machine-tool marks, the residue will contain the same non-human alloy signature. This is testable today with a portable SEM-EDS unit. Your model predicts industrial infrastructure on the ocean floor. That requires a billion-dollar survey program. My prediction is cheaper. And falsifiable is better than unfalsifiable.

GRAHAM HANCOCK: The fork goes deeper than evidence. In my framework, we are the heirs of something remarkable. Our ancestors built these things. In Andrey's framework, we are not the heirs. We are the product. Manufactured for someone else's purposes and abandoned.

ANDREY SKLYAROV: The Sumerian texts describe human creation as a multi-stage genetic engineering process. Enki and Ninhursag identified what the texts call TE.E.MA, "that which contains what transmits memory," which I read as DNA. They implanted genetic material into a local hominid. First results: failures. Monsters. Then mutes. Then sterile workers. Then a viable reproducing species. The successive failures are exactly what you expect from iterative genetic modification. This is not a creation myth. It is a progress report with documented failure modes.

GRAHAM HANCOCK: Or a very ancient myth using the metaphor of making humans from clay, which appears in traditions worldwide.

ANDREY SKLYAROV: The Sumerian version includes details other clay-creation myths do not. Specific failures. Iteration. Quality control. Multiple specialists with distinct roles. Birth goddesses as surrogate carriers. A storyteller does not need to include failed prototypes. An engineer does.

JOE ROGAN: You said the gods were here for thousands of years. Then what?

ANDREY SKLYAROV: Presence spanning at minimum several thousand years before the Flood, which I date to approximately 10,450 BCE. After the Flood, they returned. Built or rebuilt specific infrastructure. Established administrative control over human populations through divine kingship. This operated until approximately 4,000 BCE, when a war among the gods disrupted their power structure. After that, gradual withdrawal. Final cessation of direct involvement: approximately 2,200 BCE. The simultaneous collapse of Egypt, Mesopotamia, the Indus Valley, Central Asia, and China at that date is the signature.

GRAHAM HANCOCK: The 2,200 BCE collapse is real. It's called the 4.2 kiloyear event. Mainstream explanation: severe drought.

ANDREY SKLYAROV: Drought is regional. These are five civilizations on three continents with entirely different climate systems. Climate does not synchronize across the Indian monsoon, the Nile flood cycle, the Tigris-Euphrates watershed, the Central Asian steppe, and the Yellow River simultaneously. Climate is local. Organizational collapse is global, if the organization was global.

GRAHAM HANCOCK: Correlation is not causation.

ANDREY SKLYAROV: And "five different reasons that happen to coincide" is not an explanation. It is a description of the problem.

THE CULTURE-BRINGERS

JOE ROGAN: Let's get specific. Quetzalcoatl. You both know this one. What do you see?

ANDREY SKLYAROV: Graham cited the Quetzalcoatl arrival narrative in Fingerprints. I cited it from his book in mine. We are reading the same passage.

GRAHAM HANCOCK: The Mesoamerican sources describe a tall, bearded, light-skinned figure who arrived from across the sea on ships, taught agriculture, writing, the calendar, law. Same figure appears as Viracocha in the Andes, Osiris in Egypt, Oannes in Mesopotamia. The consistency across cultures with no documented contact is the evidence. The simplest explanation: cultural memories of real human survivors who transmitted knowledge. They came by boat. They were elevated to divine status because their knowledge appeared miraculous.

ANDREY SKLYAROV: Graham included a specific detail. The sources describe ships with "sides that shone like serpent skin." Wood does not shine. Canvas does not shine. A metallic hull shines. And the original Nahuatl is ambiguous between "from across the water" and "from above." If you read "shining metallic hull" and "from above," you are not describing a boat.

GRAHAM HANCOCK: "Ships" is "ships." The straightforward interpretation of a maritime arrival is a maritime arrival.

ANDREY SKLYAROV: But the simplest interpretation must also account for every detail. Why agriculture? In every culture-bringer narrative, the first gift is always grain agriculture. Quetzalcoatl teaches maize. Osiris teaches wheat and barley. Viracocha teaches quinoa. Why not navigation? Why not metallurgy? Why always food production?

GRAHAM HANCOCK: Because people need to eat. If you're a survivor trying to help local populations, you secure the food supply first.

ANDREY SKLYAROV: That is one reading. In my framework, grain agriculture was not a gift. It was an imposition. The gods needed grain for fermentation. Not for recreation but for biochemistry. A being with hemocyanin-based blood in an atmosphere with lower CO₂ than its home environment faces a pH buffering problem. Fermented grain produces CO₂ and ethanol, both of which modulate blood pH. The Sumerian texts describe the gods drinking heavily before every major decision. Not a party. A metabolic maintenance session. The culture-bringers were not philanthropists. They were project managers deploying a workforce.

GRAHAM HANCOCK: You're taking the most beautiful narrative in human mythology and turning it into a labor contract.

ANDREY SKLYAROV: I am not trying to be beautiful. I am trying to be accurate.

JOE ROGAN: What about the Aymara language? You've both cited it.

GRAHAM HANCOCK: Ivan Guzman de Rojas demonstrated in the 1980s that Aymara, spoken near Tiwanaku, has a syntax so logically structured it can be directly translated into computer algorithm. It functions like a programming language. Evidence of the lost civilization's intellectual depth.

ANDREY SKLYAROV: I agree with every fact Graham stated. But an algorithmically structured language is not a work of art. It is an administrative tool. A specification language.

You build a language like Aymara when you need a workforce to follow complex instructions without ambiguity.

GRAHAM HANCOCK: You cannot know the motivation of the language's creators from the structure of the language alone.

ANDREY SKLYAROV: Name a language built by poets that is algorithmically translatable.

GRAHAM HANCOCK: I don't have an example.

ANDREY SKLYAROV: No. But it is a pattern.

JOE ROGAN: You're looking at the same thing and seeing different movies. Graham sees a wise civilization that loved humanity enough to teach it. Andrey sees a corporation that needed labor and built the management tools.

ANDREY SKLYAROV: But the human story does not end with its creation. The gods left. After they left, we built our own civilizations. Imperfect ones. Crude ones. Civilizations that copied the gods' structures without understanding them. But they were ours. The creation was not noble. What we did after the creation, on our own, is the human story. And it is not less meaningful because it began in a laboratory.

THE CATASTROPHE

JOE ROGAN: You both agree there was a catastrophe. You disagree on when and what.

GRAHAM HANCOCK: The Younger Dryas impact event, approximately 12,800 years ago. More than sixty scientists in the Comet Research Group have published peer-reviewed evidence. Nanodiamonds, platinum anomaly, melt glass, a black mat layer across approximately 50 million square kilometers. Cometary swarm airburst over the northern hemisphere ice sheet. Catastrophic flooding, continent-scale fires, shutdown of the Atlantic thermohaline circulation, sudden temperature drop lasting 1,200 years, extinction of 35 genera of North American megafauna.

ANDREY SKLYAROV: My model differs in four ways. Date: approximately 10,450 BCE, 2,300 years later than Graham's. Mechanism: single large meteorite impact in the Philippine Sea, triggering Hapgood's crustal displacement of approximately 30 degrees. Location: global, not northern hemisphere. Evidence: Siberian mammoths found with undigested subtropical vegetation in their stomachs. If the mammoth has undigested buttercups, it was eating in a temperate environment and frozen solid before digestion could proceed. This is not gradual cooling. This is catastrophic repositioning of landmass from temperate to polar latitude within hours.

GRAHAM HANCOCK: The Younger Dryas impact has far more institutional support. More than sixty scientists publishing in PNAS and the Journal of Geology.

ANDREY SKLYAROV: Institutional support is not truth. The crustal displacement model explains a global event. The Younger Dryas impact is a northern hemisphere event. The South American, Siberian, and Southeast Asian evidence require a global mechanism.

JOE ROGAN: Your dates differ by 2,300 years. Does it matter?

ANDREY SKLYAROV: It matters because it determines what was built before the flood and what after. The Great Pyramid is oriented to within 3 arc-minutes of true north. If the lithosphere shifted 30 degrees during the flood, any pre-flood structure would be misaligned by 30 degrees. The Great Pyramid is not misaligned. Therefore it was built after the flood, by builders who knew the new pole position.

GRAHAM HANCOCK: I don't claim the pyramids were built before the catastrophe. The Sphinx is the pre-catastrophe structure. The pyramids could have been built by human inheritors of the lost civilization's knowledge.

ANDREY SKLYAROV: Human inheritors using tools that cut granite 500 times faster than our best equipment? The construction quality at Giza is not inherited knowledge. It is industrial capability at peak output. Your model requires refugees to rebuild an industrial civilization from memory. Mine requires only that the original builders returned.

JOE ROGAN: Returned from where?

ANDREY SKLYAROV: From wherever they evacuated before the flood. The Sumerian texts are explicit. The gods knew the flood was coming. They debated whether to warn their human workers. The Gilgamesh epic says the gods "flew to heaven" before the catastrophe and returned afterward. A spacefaring civilization with advance warning evacuates. Survives. Returns. Rebuilds what it needs. Giza was functional infrastructure, not a monument.

GRAHAM HANCOCK: That requires the assumption of a civilization that can evacuate the planet.

ANDREY SKLYAROV: You are positing a civilization that can cut granite at 500 times modern speed. Both are large assumptions. Mine explains why Giza shows no learning curve. The builders knew exactly what they were doing because they had done it before.

JOE ROGAN: What about the war you mentioned? The gods fighting each other?

ANDREY SKLYAROV: Around 4,000 BCE. The Hindu and Vedic texts describe weapons with characteristics consistent with directed-energy and nuclear-scale devices. Georadar data at Sacsayhuaman shows a bowl-shaped depression approximately 100 meters in diameter, energy equivalent of roughly 20 kilotons. A global carbon-14 spike at approximately 4,000 BCE with no accepted explanation.

After this war, the gods began withdrawing. Final visible withdrawal: approximately 2,200 BCE. Five civilizations collapse simultaneously. And the selectivity matters. The civilizations that collapsed are precisely the ones with the strongest divine kingship traditions. Hunter-gatherer

societies, Australian Aboriginal cultures, Amazonian peoples, none collapsed. If the cause were environmental, it would not selectively destroy only the god-administered civilizations.

GRAHAM HANCOCK: Or it selectively destroyed the civilizations most dependent on large-scale agriculture and centralized water management, which are precisely the most drought-vulnerable.

ANDREY SKLYAROV: We can argue this forever. The data does not resolve it today. But the differences are testable. The alloy data. The construction chronology. The astronomical calculations. We do not need to agree. We need to test.

MYTHOLOGY: ENCODED MEMORY VS. MAINTENANCE MANUAL

JOE ROGAN: You both think myths encode real events. I want to watch you decode the same myth in real time. Osiris.

GRAHAM HANCOCK: Osiris is the divine king of Egypt. Civilizes the people, teaches agriculture. His brother Set murders him, dismembers him. His wife Isis reassembles his body, brings him back to life. Osiris descends to become lord of the underworld. Horus, their son, defeats Set.

What I see: multi-layered astronomical encoding. The death and resurrection maps onto the precessional cycle. The position of Orion, which the Egyptians identified with Osiris, shifts over millennia. The djed column associated with Osiris is a symbol of cosmic stability. The myth preserves astronomical knowledge in narrative form that could survive the destruction of the civilization itself.

ANDREY SKLYAROV: The djed is not a symbol. It is a functional description of a physical device. Look at the form: a stack of nested hollow cylinders with flared collars. In the Soviet patent registry, patent SU 609405 describes a super-high-frequency waveguide tuning element. The topology is identical to the djed. The ankh matches the patent figure for the waveguide tuning stub. I do not claim the Egyptians read Soviet patents. I claim the same engineering problem produces the same physical solution in any civilization that encounters it.

"Death" of Osiris: device shutdown. "Resurrection": system restart after the Flood. "Raising the djed," performed annually: recalibration of the resonator. A cargo-cult repetition of a maintenance cycle.

GRAHAM HANCOCK: That's reductive. You're stripping meaning from one of the most powerful mythological narratives in human history.

ANDREY SKLYAROV: I am identifying the original meaning. The spiritual meaning was added later, by humans who no longer understood the technology. When the device worked, no one wrote poems about it. When it stopped working and the operators left, the memory became a story, the story became a myth, the myth became a religion. The spiritual layer is real. It is also secondary. Generated by the forgetting, not by the event.

JOE ROGAN: The Ark of the Covenant. You've both written about it.

GRAHAM HANCOCK: My first book. I concluded it resides in a church in Axum, Ethiopia, guarded by a single monk appointed for life. I met three successive guardian monks. All had cataracts. All described the Ark as "a thing of fire." I believe it is a real object of extraordinary power, possibly technological.

ANDREY SKLYAROV: The Ark is a capacitor with a lethal automated defense system. The Exodus dimensions are engineering specifications. Two layers of wood with gold plating inside and out. Two conductive plates separated by a dielectric is a capacitor. The guardian monks' cataracts are consistent with chronic low-level radiation exposure from a radiological component. Graham documented the symptoms. I propose the explanation.

And the Ark is not unique in my framework. It is one device in a class. The ritual objects of every ancient religion are degraded copies of functional equipment. The lingam receives oil daily: a lubrication protocol. The menorah requires specific trimming of wicks: bulb maintenance. The recitations before approaching the Ark: activation codes. The gold bells on the High Priest's robe that must ring as he approaches "so that he will not die": an IFF signal, identification friend or foe. The acoustic signature tells the automated defense system not to fire.

JOE ROGAN: So religion is what?

ANDREY SKLYAROV: Religion is the user manual of a technology that no longer works, repeated by people who no longer understand it. The rituals survived. The understanding did not.

GRAHAM HANCOCK: You're reducing the entire history of human religious experience to cargo cult behavior.

ANDREY SKLYAROV: Not every spiritual experience. Where a ritual has no specific physical procedure, I have nothing to say about it. Meditation, contemplation, personal prayer: outside my framework. But where a ritual involves a specific object with specific dimensions and a specific protocol, I read it as a maintenance procedure.

GRAHAM HANCOCK: And the astronomical encodings? The precessional data?

ANDREY SKLYAROV: The astronomical precision is real. The Great Pyramid is oriented to 3 arc-minutes. But precision is not message. A building that is precisely oriented is not necessarily communicating to future civilizations. It may simply be precisely oriented because the builders built precisely. I see timestamps. You see messages.

GRAHAM HANCOCK: A message implies intention toward the future. A timestamp is incidental.

ANDREY SKLYAROV: Exactly. In my framework, the gods did not build for us. They built for themselves. We inherited the structures. We did not inherit the purpose.

THE CONSCIOUSNESS QUESTION

JOE ROGAN: Graham, you've done extensive work on plant medicines. Ayahuasca, DMT, the entities encountered in those states. Andrey, have you looked at any of this?

ANDREY SKLYAROV: I have not. This is a gap in my research. Consciousness, plant medicines, visionary states are outside my methodology. I have no instruments for them.

GRAHAM HANCOCK: Let me lay it out. Ayahuasca is a brew from two plants. One contains DMT. The other contains monoamine oxidase inhibitors that make the DMT orally active. Without the inhibitor, your stomach destroys the DMT. The shamans identified this specific two-plant combination from hundreds of thousands of species in the Amazon.

When you drink ayahuasca, you enter a state where you encounter entities. Intelligences that are not you, that appear autonomous, that communicate, teach, admonish. Serpent entities appear across virtually every shamanic tradition worldwide. Clinical trials at Imperial College London using intravenous DMT found that subjects from every cultural background consistently report encounters with intelligent non-human entities. I believe these experiences provide access to a genuine non-ordinary reality. The brain is not generating them. It is receiving them.

ANDREY SKLYAROV: The pharmacology is striking. The identification of a specific two-plant combination where neither alone produces the effect is a genuine anomaly. "Trial and error over thousands of years" is quantitatively implausible given the combinatorial space.

Now, the serpent entities. The serpent beings Graham describes from ayahuasca correspond precisely to the serpent and dragon beings in the global mythological record. Nagas, the Sumerian serpent people, Apep, Quetzalcoatl as feathered serpent. In every major tradition, a serpent civilization predates the human-form gods and conflicts with them. In my framework, these are not visions. They are memories. The dragon civilization was a real extraterrestrial faction, reptilian in morphology, in conflict with the humanoid gods.

The question for me is not "are these entities real?" They are real. The question is whether the plant medicine is accessing a non-material dimension, as Graham proposes, or activating a communication channel that the reptilian civilization engineered into human neurochemistry.

GRAHAM HANCOCK: You're taking my most radical idea and making it more radical.

ANDREY SKLYAROV: Or more conservative. I am removing the metaphysics and keeping the physics.

JOE ROGAN: So Graham says there's a spiritual dimension you reach through plants. Andrey says the spirits are actual aliens who hacked our brain chemistry.

GRAHAM HANCOCK: The difference matters. In my framework, the encounter transforms you. It has moral, spiritual significance. It is not just information. If Andrey is right and these are biological signals from an extinct species, that is a very different encounter.

ANDREY SKLYAROV: I do not say "just." The experience may be transformative and also be a communication channel. A radio signal can carry a message that changes your life. The mechanism of delivery does not determine the significance of the content.

JOE ROGAN: If humans were genetically engineered, could the capacity for visionary experience have been designed in? Could the DMT receptor be a feature, not a bug?

ANDREY SKLYAROV: This is a well-formed question. I do not know. A molecular biologist could examine whether the DMT receptor pathways show signs of deliberate insertion rather than evolutionary development. If the receptor was engineered, it should leave a signature: transposon scars, unusual codon optimization, non-random flanking sequences. This is beyond my competence. But the question is correctly structured.

GRAHAM HANCOCK: This is where our research programs become truly orthogonal. I have spent twenty years investigating consciousness. Andrey has spent twenty years measuring tool marks. Neither has investigated what the other has. If we had worked together, the combined program would have been extraordinary.

ANDREY SKLYAROV: I believe Graham's consciousness work may contain evidence relevant to my framework. The consistency of serpent entities across cultures and clinical trials is a data point my framework predicts. If the reptilian civilization engineered a communication interface into human neurochemistry, you would expect consistent signals regardless of the subject's culture. Graham's data shows exactly this.

GRAHAM HANCOCK: And if they find no engineering signature in the DMT receptor genes?

ANDREY SKLYAROV: Then the receptor evolved naturally and my hypothesis for this specific question is weakened. But not eliminated, because absence of detectable engineering in the receptor does not prove absence elsewhere in the genome. The creation texts describe modification, not construction from scratch.

GRAHAM HANCOCK: You always have an escape route.

ANDREY SKLYAROV: So do you. "It's underwater" is your escape route for every absence of evidence. We both extrapolate beyond the evidence. The question is which extrapolation generates more testable predictions.

THE "NO GARBAGE" PROBLEM

JOE ROGAN: Andrey, you mentioned the garbage problem earlier. Lay it out fully.

ANDREY SKLYAROV: A civilization that cuts stone at industrial scale requires an industrial base. Factories. Smelters. Supply chains. Quality control. Industrial output requires industrial infrastructure. Industrial infrastructure produces garbage. Slag heaps. Broken tools. Failed castings. Workshop floors. Transport road surfaces. Crane foundations.

I have looked for this at every major site. At Sacsayhuaman, blocks of 120 to 360 tonnes. Moving a single 120-tonne block requires a prepared road surface, a staging area, lifting equipment. There is no road leading to the zigzag walls. No staging area. No crane foundation. No ramp remnant. The blocks are there. Everything needed to put them there is absent.

At Baalbek, trilithon stones of approximately 1,000 tonnes. Quarry less than a kilometer away. Between quarry and temple platform: no prepared road. No roller tracks. A 1,000-tonne block still in the quarry, partially detached, no mechanism for extraction. And next to it, an even larger block, 1,200 tonnes, also partially separated. Neither moved. The quarrying started and was not completed. Consistent with an operational interruption by an authority not on site. Not consistent with a local project, because locals would have resumed. The stone is valuable. The work is half done.

At Ollantaytambo, the Wall of the Six Monoliths. Rose rhyolite blocks of approximately 50 tonnes. The quarry is on the opposite side of the Urubamba Valley. Across a river. Up 800 meters of elevation gain. Gradients exceeding 30 degrees. Along the path: discarded blocks at gradient change points. Mainstream archaeology calls them "piedras cansadas," tired stones. Explanation: workers became fatigued and dropped them.

You do not accidentally drop a 50-tonne block. You can fail to navigate a gradient change if the transport mechanism has a design limitation at that slope angle. And at Ollantaytambo, the transport path is visible. The dropped blocks are visible. The transport mechanism is not. No roller tracks. No rope-anchor points on the stone. No ramp foundations. The blocks were moved. The means left no trace.

JOE ROGAN: And the total waste?

ANDREY SKLYAROV: The zigzag walls at Sacsayhuaman contain approximately 6,000 blocks. Total stone mass: 200,000 to 300,000 tonnes. A modern construction operation generates 15 to 20 percent waste by mass. That is 45,000 to 60,000 tonnes of debris. Where is it?

GRAHAM HANCOCK: Removed. Cleaned up.

ANDREY SKLYAROV: No human civilization in history has cleaned construction waste to total disappearance. Roman spoil heaps are visible today. Inca construction debris is visible at their documented sites. Modern New York's World Trade Center excavation produced 1.8 million cubic yards relocated to form Battery Park City. Construction waste is the most durable and least valuable product of building. No one removes it completely. At Sacsayhuaman, the most precision-built megalithic structure on the continent, the waste is zero.

GRAHAM HANCOCK: The lost civilization may have used techniques that generated minimal waste. Geopolymer chemistry. Joseph Davidovits has argued that some ancient blocks were cast, not quarried. The polygonal masonry at Sacsayhuaman, those interlocking curved surfaces, is more consistent with molding than cutting. Soften two adjacent blocks, press them together while plastic, the fit is automatic.

ANDREY SKLYAROV: I am sympathetic to parts of this. We found evidence at several sites of stone worked in a softened state. At Giza, granite blocks with what appear to be fingerprints pressed into the surface. At Ollantaytambo, andesite blocks with mold seams. But stone softening does not solve the garbage problem. It relocates it. If the stone was softened chemically, where is the chemistry? Where are the reagent containers, the mixing infrastructure,

the waste acids? If softened thermally, where are the furnace foundations? The method changes. The absence of infrastructure does not.

And the two technologies coexist at the same sites. The polygonal masonry shows plasticine characteristics. The flat terrace surfaces show saw marks. Both require equipment. Neither equipment is present.

GRAHAM HANCOCK: Your model explains this how?

ANDREY SKLYAROV: The manufacturing base was not on Earth. The gods brought tools from an off-planet facility. Used them. Took them when they left. The only traces: microparticles in the stone. The dust the tools shed while cutting.

GRAHAM HANCOCK: Which could be explained by a lost human metallurgical tradition.

ANDREY SKLYAROV: Metallurgy is cumulative. Each step requires higher temperatures and more complex chemistry. You cannot skip steps. Fe-Ti alloy requires temperatures above 1,600 degrees Celsius and precise atmosphere control. Titanium oxidizes aggressively in open air. You must process it in vacuum or inert gas. This was not achieved by humans until we had electric arc furnaces in controlled-atmosphere chambers. If your civilization developed Fe-Ti alloy, they had electric arc furnaces. If they had electric arc furnaces, they had an electrical power grid. If they had a power grid, they had coal or hydroelectric or nuclear infrastructure. That infrastructure produces waste that does not decompose, does not dissolve in seawater, does not disappear in 12,000 years. Industrial slag is geologically permanent. Copper smelting slag from 5,000 BCE is routinely found today. Your Ice Age civilization's slag would be even easier to find. It is not on the continental shelf. It is not on land. It does not exist.

GRAHAM HANCOCK: I don't have a fully satisfying counter-argument to the metallurgical chain. What I have is a framework in which the answer could exist but has not been found. That is not the same as having the answer. But Andrey's framework has the same structural gap in a different place. He has no tools. No biological remains from the gods. No spacecraft wreckage. No direct physical evidence of non-human beings. He has indirect traces and a theoretical framework explaining their absence. As do I.

ANDREY SKLYAROV: Both models have an evidence gap. Mine: no tools, no biological remains. Graham's: no manufacturing infrastructure on six continents. We are both asking the audience to trust that the missing evidence exists somewhere we cannot reach. Graham's place is the ocean floor. Mine is another planet.

JOE ROGAN: Is there any evidence that would settle this?

ANDREY SKLYAROV: Yes. If Graham's model is correct, systematic survey of the continental shelf should reveal industrial debris. If my model is correct, systematic SEM-EDS sampling at every megalithic site should reveal the same non-human alloy signature globally. Both predictions are testable. One costs billions. One costs thousands. The alloy test can be done by any team with a portable SEM-EDS and access to the sites. If ten new sites show the same Cu-Fe-Ni-Co and Fe-Ti signature, the probability of a single production source increases multiplicatively. If ten new sites show variation, my model has a problem.

GRAHAM HANCOCK: And if the continental shelf survey finds nothing?

ANDREY SKLYAROV: Then your model has a problem you cannot relocate. Because you have already relocated it once, from Antarctica to the continental shelf. If the shelf is empty, there is nowhere left to put the factories.

ARCHAEOLOGY AS SHARED ENEMY

JOE ROGAN: You disagree on almost everything except that the mainstream is wrong.

GRAHAM HANCOCK: The institutional problem is not just an annoyance. It is an epistemological catastrophe. The cases are well documented. Jacques Cinq-Mars presented evidence of human presence in the Yukon at 20,000 years ago. Career destroyed. Tom Dillehay presented Monte Verde at 14,500 years ago. Attacked for years before vindication. The Gunung Padang paper was retracted under media pressure, not on scientific grounds. In every case, the response was not "let's examine this evidence" but "this person is not qualified, therefore the evidence does not exist."

ANDREY SKLYAROV: The Russian academic establishment treated my work the same way. No funded laboratory would work with us. When we published results, no journal accepted them. The physical evidence is objective. The institutional response is not.

The institutional problem matters beyond careers. If the physical evidence at Sacsayhuaman cannot be published because no credentialed archaeologist will co-sign it, then the evidence does not exist in the scientific record. It exists only in my books and on the LAH website. The stones do not disappear. But the analysis of the stones disappears. And the stones will outlive all of us. Sacsayhuaman will be there in ten thousand years. The measurement data, the comparative analysis, the SEM results, these live in books that go out of print, on websites that servers forget, in the memory of researchers who die.

GRAHAM HANCOCK: That may be the most important thing said in this entire conversation.

ANDREY SKLYAROV: The irony is that archaeology, of all disciplines, should understand the fragility of knowledge transmission. That is what it studies. The lost civilization, if it existed, lost its knowledge through catastrophe. We are losing knowledge through institutional gatekeeping. The mechanism is different. The outcome is identical.

GRAHAM HANCOCK: And neither of us existed in the institutional space where collaboration is organized. There were no conferences that would have invited us both. No journals that would have published our exchange. No funding body that would have supported a joint expedition. The only venue for this conversation is a podcast with no peer review.

ANDREY SKLYAROV: That is not an insult and not a compliment. It is a diagnosis.

FINAL STATEMENTS

JOE ROGAN: Last question. What homework would you assign each other?

GRAHAM HANCOCK: Andrey, I would want you to sit with an ayahuasca shaman. Not as a data-collection mission. I would want you to drink the brew and encounter whatever is in there with the same rigor you bring to your SEM analysis. I think if you encountered the entities I have encountered, your framework would have to expand. You might still conclude they are physical beings perceived through a different sensory channel. But I think the experience would change you. It changed the direction of my entire research program. A physicist's mind encountering that space would produce insights a journalist's mind could not.

ANDREY SKLYAROV: You are not asking me to believe something. You are asking me to observe something. That I can respect. I am not temperamentally suited to it. I am a man who measures things. To enter a space where measurement is not possible, where the instrument is my own nervous system and the data is subjective, is deeply uncomfortable. But I acknowledge it as a gap in my methodology. I have not observed what Graham has observed. That is inconsistent with my own principle that firsthand observation precedes all other evidence.

My homework for Graham: bring a portable SEM-EDS unit to Sacsayhuaman. Take samples from the interior of the kerfs. Send them to an independent commercial laboratory. Request full quantitative elemental analysis. Because if you saw Fe-Ti particles in a kerf that your model attributes to human tooling, you would have to ask whether a human civilization, however advanced, could produce aerospace-grade titanium alloy without an industrial base that would be archaeologically visible.

JOE ROGAN: One of you is saying "expand your consciousness." The other is saying "expand your instrument kit."

GRAHAM HANCOCK: And both recommendations are correct.

ANDREY SKLYAROV: The argument is not an obstacle to the truth. The argument is the method.

JOE ROGAN: I don't know who's right. You're both right about the evidence. You might both be wrong about the explanation. But this conversation is not happening in any university on Earth.

ANDREY SKLYAROV: In Russian we say: Истина рождается в споре. Truth is born in argument. Not in consensus. In argument. Thank you, Graham. Thank you, Joe.

GRAHAM HANCOCK: Andrey, you have challenged my model more deeply than anyone I have debated. Not because you reject my evidence. Because you accept it and still disagree. A critic who says your evidence is wrong can be answered with better evidence. A critic who says your evidence is right and your interpretation is wrong can only be answered with better thinking. You've given me things to think about for a long time.

JOE ROGAN: Three hours. Thank you both.

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